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Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1959-1960

Coverage Date: 1959 AD - 1960 AD

Place Coverage

Uluguru Mountains, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S): JOKING AND PRIVILEGED FAMILIARITY

A high degree of familiarity is permitted between alternate generations, and it is permissible for a youth to deride a mtani elder if at some time during the exchange he shows the proper respect. For example, a elder named Mbewa ("rat" in Luguru) approached the house of a young mtani and the latter started calling to those around to "kill the rat, kill the rat." The elder did not take offence, but, playing the game, threatened to kill the young man and chased him away with his walking staff. The young man returned shortly and greeted the elder in a respectful manner. It is also regarded as amusing to erroneously inform a mtani elder that someone has died and that his presence is required at a burial, or to tell someone at work on their farm they are needed at home. As farms may be two or three hours walking distance through the mountains, this can be something less than a laughing matter to the victim.

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One type of bantering and joking that is not limited to watani is that between grandparents and grandchildren. The kinship terminology permits alternating generations to refer to each other as "brother" or "sister," and a young man may tease his grandfather about marrying his wife. The identification of alternate generations with each other is rather strong, and grandparents tend to take the part of the children against parents. When a parent would slap or strike a child, the grandparent might say "Why do you beat me?"

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The Luguru case deviates from the common pattern of joking relationships in that reciprocal or symmetrical joking is permitted between contiguous generations of watani. It is not uncommon in the literature to find examples where it is permissible for a man to appropriate the property of a particular individual, such as a mother's brother. Indeed, a Luguru may walk off with the belongings of his maternal uncle without permission. If a youth needed a goat for a marriage payment, he could take one from his mother's brother, and the

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latter could not object. However, this is not part of the utani relationship, as the two are from the same clan. While joking is permitted between watani of first ascending or descending generations, it tends to be qualitatively different from that between watani of the same generation. It does not often involve sexual matters or obscenity (though it may), and is more likely to be of the erroneous message type listed above, taking property for ransom (see below), or joking at funerals.

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Regarding the latter, considerable horseplay by the watani clan or clans of the deceased is permitted and expected at a burial. Attendance of some watani is required, and as a burial is a sad and serious affair, they attempt to introduce a bit of levity into the otherwise sorrowful occasion. To the crying woman they may say "Keep quiet, or we will come back tomorrow," thus threatening to delay the burial. They have been known to pour a pot of water  1318 over a wailing woman under these circumstances. Or again, a mtani might say to the clan of the deceased: "You are crying too much. Give me one woman to take to my house so that I can give you a child to resemble the person who is dead." A mtani may lie down in the grave and pretend to sleep or demand a small sum of money to get out of the grave so the burial can continue. Preparation of the grave is the privilege of the watani, and they have been known to beat a member of the clan of the deceased who got into the grave. However, this was done in a jocular manner and without harm to the victim.

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